

And when they first took a captive, one fated to die, forthwith they slew him there before the gods; they slashed his breast open with a flint knife.

And when the city had been overcome, thereupon were counted as many captives as there were, and as many Mexicans and Tlatilulcans as had died. Then they apprised the ruler that they had been orphaned for the sake of Uitzilpochtli; that men had been taken captive and been slain. And the ruler then commanded the high judges to go to tell and inform all in the homes of those who had gone to die in war, that there might be weeping in the homes of those who had gone to war to die. And they informed those in the homes of as many as had gone to take captives in war that they received honors there because of their valor. And they were rewarded according to their merits; the ruler accorded favors to all—costly capes, breech cloths, chocolate, food, and devices, and lip rods and ear plugs. Even more did the ruler accord favors to the princes if they had taken captives. He gave them the offices of stewards, and all wealth without price—honor, fame, renown.

And if some had done wrong in battle, they then and there slew them on the battlefield; they beat them, they stoned them.

And if several claimed one captive, and one man said, "He is my captive," and another man also said, "He is my captive": if no man verified it, and also if no one saw how they had taken the captive, the lord of the sun decided between them. If neither had an advantage of the two who claimed the captive, then those who had taken four captives, the masters of the captives, decided that to neither one would the captive belong. He was dedicated to the Uitzcalco [or] they left him to the tribal temple, the house of the devil.

And when the city which they had destroyed was attained, at once was set the tribute, the impost. [To the ruler who had conquered them] they gave that which was there made. And likewise, forthwith a steward was placed in office who would watch over and levy the tribute.

2. THE HALLS OF MOCTEZUMA

The political organization of the Aztec state on the eve of the Spanish Conquest represented a mixture of theocracy and royal absolutism. The barbaric splendor and elaborate ceremonial that marked the household of the great war chief Moctezuma are vividly described by an eyewitness, the conquistador and historian Bernal Díaz del Castillo (1492–1581?).

Bernal Díaz del Castillo, *Historia verdadera de la conquista de Nueva España*, 4 vols. (Buenos Aires, 1914), vol. 2, pp. 31–33. Excerpt translated by the editors.

The great Moctezuma was close to forty years old, of good height and well proportioned, slender and lean. His skin was not particularly dark but the proper color and shade for an Indian. He wore his hair not too long, just so it covered his ears; his few whiskers were dark, well trimmed, and sparse. His face was rather long and cheerful with pleasant eyes, and he showed in his expression and in his gaze, at times affection and when necessary sternness. He was very neat and clean, bathing daily in the afternoons. He had many concubines, the daughters of lords, but he also had two legitimate wives who were chiefs in their own right. When he slept with them it was done so secretly that only a few of the servants knew about it. He was quite free of sodomies ["unnatural" sex acts]. The robes or clothes that he wore one day were not worn again for three or four days. He had a guard of over 200 chieftains in rooms adjacent to his and only a select few were permitted to speak to him. When they went to talk with him, they had to take off their fancy cloaks and put on others of less value (although clean) and they had to enter barefoot and with their eyes downcast. They made three bows and with each bow they had to say: "Lord, my Lord, my great Lord." When they had delivered their message, he dispatched them with just a few words. They didn't turn their backs on him as they took their leave but faced him with their eyes on the ground, and they didn't turn their backs as they were leaving.

And another thing I noticed: that when the great Lords who came from faraway lands on legal matters or business arrived at Moctezuma's dwelling, they had to go barefoot and with modest robes, and they couldn't enter straight into the palace but had to wait awhile beside the door, because to enter in a hurry was considered disrespectful.

As regards eating, his cooks prepared over thirty different types of dishes which they kept warm by placing them over small clay braziers. From the dishes offered to the great Moctezuma, they produced over 300 meals and sometimes as many as 1,000 for his guard. On these festival occasions Moctezuma would sometimes come with his retinue and the cooks would point out the best dish and explain which fowl and other things were included, and whatever they suggested he was obliged to try. But he came only once in a while and just to pass the time. I've heard tell that they used to cook the flesh of young boys, and, since there were so many different dishes and things, no one could tell that it was human flesh because every day they cooked chickens, turkeys, pheasants, partridges, quail, tame and wild ducks, venison, wild boar, waterfowl, pigeons, hares, rabbits, and all manner of birds and things from that country of which there are so many that I'll never finish naming them—so I'll stop here. I do know for certain, that once our captain [Cortés] reprehended them for sacrificing and eating human flesh they stopped the practice.

But we'll leave off talking about this and return to the way Moctezuma was served at mealtimes. This is the way it was: if it was cold they made a big fire from the embers of a smokeless tree bark. The embers from that bark gave off a

fragrant smell and, so that it gave off no more heat than he wanted, they placed in front of it a screen worked with gold and other figures of idols. He was seated on a low stool, luxurious and soft, with a table also low and made in the same style as the stools. On this they put white table clothes and some rather long napkins of the same material. Four women, very beautiful and clean, brought him water for his hands in a kind of deep bowl called a *xical* below which they held a kind of plate to catch the water, and they handed him towels [to dry his hands]. Two other women brought him tortillas. When he had begun to eat they put in front of him a gilded wooden screen so that no one could see him eat and the four women were dismissed. Then, he was joined by four elderly lords who Moctezuma chatted with from time to time and questioned about things. To show his favor he gave each man a plate of food taken from his personal dishes. They said that those old men were his closest kinsmen and counselors and magistrates. The food Moctezuma gave them they ate standing up and with great respect, and all without looking at his face. He was served on earthenware from Cholula, some of it red and some black.

While he ate, the guards in the adjoining rooms didn't dare make a ruckus or speak loudly. The servers brought him all kinds of fruit from the region but he ate very little and only from time to time. They brought him a special cocoa drink in a sort of cup made of pure gold and they say that it was to ensure success with women so we'll look no further into it. But what I did see was that they brought him over fifty big mugs full of good frothy cocoa, and that he drank from them, and that the women served him with great deference. Occasionally at dinner time there were hunchbacked Indians—very ugly because their small bodies were bent in half. Among them were jesters and buffoons, who praised him, and others who sang or danced for him because Moctezuma was fond of entertainment and singing. To these entertainers he gave leftover food and mugs of cocoa. Meanwhile, the same four women cleared the tablecloths and gave him fresh water for his hands, always with great deference. And Moctezuma talked to those old men about issues that concerned him, and they took leave of him with great reverence, and he stayed behind to rest.

3. AZTEC INDUSTRY AND COMMERCE

Division of labor and perfection of craftsmanship among the Aztecs attained perhaps the highest point of development compatible with what was essentially an Upper Stone Age technology. The relatively vast scale on which the general exchange of goods and services was carried on is shown by the activity at the great market at Tenochtitlán, as described below by Cortés in a letter to the Emperor Charles V. Trade was not confined to Aztec territory.

The city has many squares where markets are held, and trading is carried on. There is one square, twice as large as that of Salamanca, all surrounded by arcades, where there are daily more than sixty thousand souls, buying and selling, and where are found all the kinds of merchandise produced in these countries, including food products, jewels of gold and silver, lead, brass, copper, zinc, stone, bones, shells, and feathers. Stones are sold, hewn and unhewn, adobe bricks, wood, both in the rough and manufactured in various ways. There is a street for game, where they sell every sort of bird, such as chickens, partridges, quails, wild ducks, flycatchers, widgsons, turtle-doves, pigeons, reed-birds, parrots, owls, eaglets, owlets, falcons, sparrow-hawks and kestrels, and they sell the skin of some of these birds of prey with their feathers, heads, beaks, and claws. They sell rabbits, hares, and small dogs which they castrate, and raise for the purpose of eating.

There is a street set apart for the sale of herbs, where can be found every sort of root and medical herb which grows in the country. There are houses like apothecary shops, where prepared medicines are sold, as well as liquids, ointments, and plasters. There are places like our barber shops, where they wash and shave their heads. There are houses where they supply food and drink for payment. There are men, such as in Castile are called porters, who carry burdens. There is much wood, charcoal, braziers, made of earthenware, and mats of diverse kinds for beds, and others, very thin, used as cushions, and for carpeting halls, and bedrooms. There are all sorts of vegetables, and especially onions, leeks, garlic, borage, nasturtion, watercresses, sorrel, thistles, and artichokes. There are many kinds of fruits, amongst others cherries, and prunes, like the Spanish ones. They sell bees-honey and wax, and honey made of corn stalks, which is as sweet and syrup-like as that of sugar, also honey of a plant called magney, which is better than most; from these same plants they make sugar and wine, which they also sell.

They also sell skeins of different kinds of spun cotton, in all colours, so that it seems quite like one of the silk markets of Granada, although it is on a greater scale; also as many different colours for painters as can be found in Spain and of as excellent hues. They sell deer skins with all the hair turned on them, and of different colours; much earthenware, exceedingly good, many sorts of pots, large and small, pitchers, large tiles, an infinite variety of vases, all of very singular clay, and most of them glazed and painted. They sell maize, both in the grain and made into bread, which is very superior in its quality to that of the other islands and mainland; pies of birds, and fish, also

Hernán Cortés, *Fernando Cortés, His Five Letters of Relation to the Emperor Charles V*, 2 vols., edited and translated by Francis A. McNutt (New York: Arthur H. Clark Company, 1908), vol. 1, pp. 257-259. Reprinted by permission of the publishers.